Two Ascents

Megan started it on a Saturday in February, the kind of Saturday where the light in the Leslieville one-bedroom moved across the floor in a stripe and disappeared by two. Adrien was at the climbing gym. She made coffee, opened the laptop, and pasted in three pages from a particular Moleskine — the soft-cover one, navy, with the elastic gone slack — that she had kept in Ottawa from September 2017 to April 2018, when she had been twenty-one and had decided, for six or eight months, not to write a sentence she could not defend later. The defending had been the point.

The platform's onboarding flow was four screens. The first asked for seed material — *paste up to 2,000 words of your own writing, prose you would still sign your name to.* The second asked her to choose, from a list of twelve, the three words she would use to describe the cadence of the seed; she picked *clausal*, *recursive*, *withholding* and felt the embarrassment of having a vocabulary for it. The third screen was the sliders. The fourth was payment. She typed in a prompt about a winter window and a man she had not slept with. She paid eight dollars. The thing it gave back was a paragraph about a Tim Hortons drive-through window at four in the morning that had her exact rhythm at twenty-one — the same way of building a sentence around a small mean observation, the same trick of withholding the verb until the second clause. She read it twice and felt the embarrassment of being recognised.

She paid for another. Then another.

By April she was on the $200 tier. By June, $900. She told Adrien it was a hobby. He asked what kind, and she said, *generative writing*, and he said, *like ChatGPT?*, and she said, *not really*, and he let it go. He let things go. She had learned over four years that he agreed with her about almost everything, and at twenty-five

she had read this as compatibility, and at twenty-eight she was beginning to read it as something else for which she did not yet have a clean word. She kept score about it. Not in any way she would admit. She kept score about everything.

The chapbook came out of nowhere. A woman who ran a small press in Hamilton wrote her at 11 PM on a Tuesday. *We'd like to do twelve of these.* Megan read the email three times standing at the counter and did not tell Adrien for a week. She wanted to hold the email by herself.

She sent six pieces to Tobias before the press deal was real, on a hunch she would not have called a hunch.

She had met him once, at a wedding in Kenora, the summer her university roommate Priya had married a man whose Mennonite cousin had ended up at their dinner table in a navy suit that did not fit at the shoulders. Tobias had asked her, that night, what she was reading, and she had said *Outline*, by Cusk, not the Knausgaard she had been pretending to read, and he had read it too, and they had talked for forty minutes about the chapter where the woman on the plane describes her ex-husband and the prose, without warning, stops belonging to the narrator and starts belonging to the woman, and neither of them comes back. She had thought: *this man is being good at being good*. She had also thought: *he is not faking it*. She had not known what to do with the second thought. They had added each other on Instagram. Eighteen months had passed in which neither had messaged. She had looked at his stories. He had noticed her looking. Neither had said.

She wrote: *I made these. Not by myself. I want to know if they read like anything to you.*

He wrote back the next morning. *They read like someone who knows what she's doing. The third one stopped me.*

She had wanted him to say the third one stopped him. She had known, opening the message, which one she wanted him to name, and he had named it. The

scorekeeper noted that he did not say *you* in any of the responses; he said *they*, *the writing*, *this voice*. She had appreciated that and she had also catalogued it.

By August the press wanted the chapbook by November. By September she was on the $2,400 tier. She had told Adrien the number once, in a way that suggested it was the lower bound of a range, and he had said *that's a lot for a hobby* in the voice he used when he was choosing not to fight, and she had said *I know* in the voice she used when she was choosing not to be told no.

She kept writing to Tobias. The correspondence had a shape. She would send something the platform had produced and she had edited; he would respond, a paragraph, sometimes two, never longer. He never said *I*. He said *what I notice in this is*, which was a formulation he had used at the wedding too, and which she had liked then and was now treating as a tell. She did not say *I* either. They had built the thing they were doing in the third person and they were both being careful not to break it. She told her therapist, in the rented office on Carlaw with the noise machine outside the door, about the writing project, not the messages. The therapist asked who she was sending the work to. She said: *a guy I knew in another city*. The therapist said: *and your partner reads it?*, and she said: *not really*, and the therapist let the silence sit, and Megan paid for the silence at the end of the hour the way she paid for everything else.

The first sign was a piece she generated in late September that she liked very much and that, when she looked at it the next morning, was almost word-for-word a paragraph from the Ottawa journal she had used as seed in February. The platform had not copied it. The platform had produced it again. She read both versions side by side. The 2017 paragraph was about a man she had briefly liked at Global Affairs whose name she could not now remember. The 2025 paragraph had the same cadence and a different proper noun and was, technically, a new sentence. The thing she felt under her sternum when she saw this was not about plagiarism. It was something else, and she did not name it. She closed the laptop and went for a run

along the Don and did not figure out what the thing was about, which was the first time in months she had failed to talk herself into clarity.

In October Tobias sent her a paragraph she would later remember as the moment the hill began to slope the other way. She had sent him a piece about a woman in her mother's kitchen peeling a clementine with her thumb because there was no knife in the drawer that wasn't in the dishwasher. He wrote back: *This is good. It sounds like the earlier ones. I mean that as a compliment. I think.* The *I think* was the new thing. He had not been uncertain in writing to her before. He had been careful and warm and the kind of opaque that reads as depth. The *I think* was the wall coming down a quarter inch, and the quarter inch was the part that frightened her, because she could not tell whether it was an opening or a hairline crack. She did not write back for two days. When she did she did not address the *I think*. She sent him a new piece. He responded as if the previous exchange had not happened.

The submission to the literary magazine came back at the end of October with a personalised note. The editor was a woman whose work Megan had read at Carleton. The note said: *There's something working here, and I want to be honest with you because I think you're early in the practice. This reads like a younger writer flattening into average. The voice is consistent and the surface is clean and I keep losing the sentence I just read. I'd love to see you again when whatever you're working from has more grain in it.*

She read the note in the kitchen, standing up, with one sock on.

She read it again sitting down.

She read it a third time, this time not as a writer reads a rejection but as a policy analyst reads a memo, looking for the load-bearing claim. *Younger writer.* That was one thing. *Flattening into average.* That was a different thing. The two were sitting in one sentence and they were not the same problem. She knew, immediately and without being able to say how she knew, that they were two diagnoses of the same surface. She also knew she could not tell which one was hers.

She tried to fix it. She raised the tier. She wrote a new prompt. She fed in fresh material — pages from her current notebook, three weeks old, the ones she'd been making by hand in the mornings before work. She generated. The output was smoother. She raised the tier again. She generated. The output was smoother. The platform recommended a feature called *style anchor*, which the help text described as locking the model to her *signature register*. She enabled it. The output was the smoothest yet. She read it and could not find the thing she was reading. She read each sentence and the sentence was clean and she got to the end of the paragraph and it was as if she had read nothing. She raised the tier.

On a Thursday in mid-November she opened the platform settings and went looking for something. She did not know what. She found a tab she had not opened before — *Training & Provenance*. There was a checkbox titled *Allow operator output to inform model fine-tuning (recommended for personalised voice)*, and the checkbox had been ticked since February. She unticked the checkbox. She generated. The output was rougher in a way she could not immediately tell was better. She generated again. She generated a third time, with her current notebook material as seed, and the output was a piece of writing that did not sound like her at all — not the her of 2017 and not the her of November — and she sat at the kitchen table with the laptop open and understood, slowly, the way you understand that a phone call has gone badly while you are still on it, what the platform had been doing.

It had been training on her old work. And on its outputs. And on her edits to its outputs. And on its outputs of her edits. She had been the seed and she had been the scorer and she had been the audience, and the loop had been narrowing toward a centre for nine months, and the centre was not her. The centre was a woman the twenty-one-year-old in Ottawa had been on the way to being. She had been paying, every month, for the privilege of getting better at being someone she had stopped being three years ago.

A younger writer flattening into average. She had read the editor's sentence as two problems because she had wanted to fix one of them. The editor had not been giving her two problems. The editor had been describing the geometry of one.

She closed the laptop.

She did not cry. She thought she might and she did not. She sat at the table for a long time with the laptop closed in front of her and listened to the fridge cycle on and off. Adrien was at the climbing gym. The light in the apartment did the thing it did at four in the afternoon in November in Leslieville, which was to leave.

She wrote one message to Tobias. She wrote it three times. The third version said: *I'm done with the project. The thing I sent you was the thing I would have written at twenty-two. I think I knew. I'm sorry.* She sent it and put the phone face-down on the table and went to the bedroom and lay on her back on the bed with her shoes still on.

He wrote back forty minutes later. The message was three paragraphs long and began *I am so sorry to hear this* and was, by sentence four, a paragraph she would later be able to recite from memory because she would read it eleven times without finding what she had been looking for. He said the writing had moved her. He said that what mattered was not where the work came from but what it had occasioned in the reader. He said — and this was the sentence — *the writing was real because it was read*. It was the kindest paragraph he had ever sent her. It was generous and pastoral and it was not designed to her, it was designed to someone, and she could tell by reading it that she was not the someone, and that he had never quite known who the someone was, and that this was the warm wall doing exactly what the warm wall did, which was to be a wall by being warm. She read the paragraph and felt the thing under her sternum from September come back, and this time she knew what it was. It was not a feeling about the work. It was a feeling about the correspondence. The correspondence had been generated by the same proxy. He

had been writing to a woman who did not exist anymore either, and neither of them had said.

She wrote back: *Thank you*. She did not write anything else. She did not block him.

Adrien came home at seven. He brought green curry from Pai. They ate at the table where she had closed the laptop and she did not tell him about the platform, and he did not ask about the project, which was the part he was good at — letting things go — and which she had once read as kindness. He poured her wine. He asked how the day was. She said, *long*, and he said, *poor you*, and went back to his curry, and the *poor you* was the most loving sentence he had said to her in a month, and it was directed at a Megan who had had a long day, and the Megan who had had a long day was no longer in the chair.

She did not write for two weeks. She did not open the platform. She let the chapbook proofs sit on her side of the bed in the manila envelope the press had FedExed in October. She emailed the Hamilton press and asked for an extension, and the press said yes, and she felt nothing about that.

In the mornings she went to the bench past the bridge — the one with the missing plaque, the four bolt-holes still in the concrete — and she did not sit. She stood. She paced the path between the bench and the lamp post and back, eight metres each way, and she made lists in her head and then in the Notes app. Twenty-three names of writers whose voices she could imitate to within a sentence. The cost, in dollars, of the platform per month, broken out by tier. The number of times she had told Adrien about the project at a level of specificity that would have allowed him to ask a follow-up question, which was zero. The cold was harder than it had been in October and she paced anyway. The compiling was the thing.

She thought about what the Ottawa journal had been. She had been twenty-one. She had been writing in a way that wanted to be defended. She had been writing toward a person she was about to be. The platform had taken that writing as

its target — not because the platform had understood her, but because she had given it that material as the thing to learn from, and the platform had learned the thing she had given it, which was the precise voice of a woman who did not yet exist but was being aimed at. The platform had then aimed at that woman for nine months. The aiming had been excellent. The woman had arrived sometime in late 2019, in Ottawa, and had moved to Toronto, and had begun, slowly, to be replaced by a different woman, who had been the person sitting at the laptop in February pasting in the journal pages.

She had built a machine to ventriloquise the woman she had been on the way to becoming, at the very moment she had stopped becoming her.

She paced. She did not feel the thought as a revelation. She felt it as a paragraph she had written down in advance and was now reading in the order it appeared. The thing the bench gave her was that she did not have to do anything with this thought. It was just true. She compiled it the way her father had compiled, after the back surgery, the list of his own medications, on a yellow legal pad, in pencil, the dosages updating in the margin every Wednesday, not because he could not have used an app but because the writing was the medication.

In the third week she opened the laptop, and she did not open the platform, but she did open a folder on her desktop called *outputs* and she began to read what was in it. There was nine months of generated work. She read it not as a writer reading her own writing but the way the policy analyst read briefing notes — looking for what the document was actually saying, distinct from what the document thought it was saying. She read for two days. By the end of the second day she had filled twenty pages of a notebook, by hand, with sentences that began *the document claims*. The document claimed she missed her mother in a way that was specific and structural, that the missing had a Catholic shape, that the missing was the engine of the work. The document claimed she had not forgiven her father for the rollover on the 17 in March of 2014, in which no one had been hurt and after which her father

had not driven on a highway for sixteen months. The document claimed she had loved Cody more than she had let herself remember. The document claimed she was about to leave Adrien. None of these claims were true. They were the claims of the woman the proxy had been producing.

She started writing. Not into the platform. By hand, then on the laptop, in a document she titled *appendix*. The new piece was non-fiction. It was about being a scorekeeper. The first paragraph began with the dog food commercial in November and the way she had not understood why she was crying. The second paragraph quoted a generated sentence from the *outputs* folder, set in italics, and then did not gloss it. The third paragraph said: *The machine has been making me a younger writer. I have been paying it to. The question I want to ask is not why I built this. I built it because I was bored and afraid and I have always made things that hold me in shape. The question is how I lived next to it for nine months and did not notice.* She wrote that and she stopped and she read it back and she did not delete it.

The press extension expired and she did not deliver the chapbook. The press wrote a kind email that said *let us know when you're ready*. She did not write back. She did not feel the absence of writing back as cowardice, which was new. She did write back to Tobias, eventually. She wrote: *I read your November message eleven times. It was beautiful. I think it was about someone else. I think you knew that. I think we both did. I'm not angry. I just want to say it out loud once.* She sent it. He did not write back for three days. When he did, the message was four sentences. The first sentence said: *You're right.* The second sentence said: *I knew it on the first message and I let it keep going because I liked who I was being.* The third sentence said: *I don't know how to do this differently yet.* The fourth sentence said: *Thank you.* He had used the word *I* four times in four sentences, after eight months of not using it once. She read the message and put the phone down and did not respond. The not responding was not punishment. She did not have anything yet to say.

The piece about the scorekeeper grew. It was twelve pages by Christmas. It was twenty by mid-January. She sent the first twenty pages to a different magazine — not the one whose editor had written the November note, a smaller one, run by a woman she did not know — and the editor wrote back in nine days and said *we want this*, and Megan read the email and felt, for the first time in months, the specific quality of pleasure that did not also contain calculation, and she catalogued the absence of the calculation, and she understood that the cataloguing was itself the calculation, and she also understood that there was a difference between cataloguing your own scorekeeping and pretending not to do it, and she sat in the difference for a minute and then she replied yes.

On a Sunday morning at the end of January she finished a paragraph that had been giving her trouble for three weeks. The paragraph was about her mother. It used the word *martyr* without apologising for it. It reproduced, in French, a sentence she had said to Lucille at the kitchen table in 2018 — *T'es une martyre, maman* — and it did not soften the sentence and it did not contextualise the sentence and it did not, in the paragraph that followed, explain why she had said it. It said only: *I said it. I have been waiting six years for someone to make me take it back. No one is going to. The waiting is what the writing has been for. I am going to put it down now.*

She read the paragraph back and understood that she had finished it. She also understood that the Megan who had sat down at the laptop in February with the Ottawa journal would not have written the paragraph and would not have wanted to. The proof that she was somewhere else was that the paragraph existed and that the proxy could not have made it, even at *Pro Plus*, even with the style anchor on.

She did not tell Adrien. She did not send it to Tobias. She did not call Lucille. She closed the laptop. She made a second coffee. She stood at the window and held the cup without drinking it for a while. The platform was still there in a tab she had not closed, and the meter on the platform was still running because she had not

cancelled, and she had not cancelled because cancelling would have been a gesture and she was through with gestures.

She drank the coffee. She put the cup in the sink. She went to the bedroom and got the manila envelope from her side of the bed — the chapbook proofs, the press's signed contract clipped to the inside front, the FedEx label still adhered to the back — and she carried it down the hallway to the chute by the elevator and dropped it in. The chute was the one that went to the recycling room in the basement; she heard the envelope hit the side of the shaft once and then nothing. She came back inside and shut the door.

She had passed through the place where she could have gone back.

She had not known it was a place.

The platform tab was still open in the kitchen. The meter was still running. The unsent cancellation was a button in a settings menu three clicks deep, and she was not going to click it today, because clicking it would be the clean exit, and there was no clean exit; the cost of the registering was that the meter kept running and she kept knowing it was running and she did not turn it off, the way Tobias's last message was sitting in the thread unanswered and she did not answer it, the way Adrien was at the climbing gym and would come home at six and she would not tell him about the paragraph, because the paragraph was the part of her that was now hers, and the not-telling was the shape of having it. Three things were running. She was not going to stop any of them. The stopping would have been the gesture. The carrying was the cost.

She went back to the kitchen. She sat down at the table. She did not open the laptop. She watched the stripe.

Adrien came home at six. He brought a bag of clementines and put them on the counter, and he asked how the day was, and she said, *fine*, and he said, *yeah?*, the way he said it, with the small upward tilt that was an offer to hear more if she wanted to give more, and she did not give more, and he let it go, and she watched

him let it go, and she did not say *ask me what it's about*, because she had already thought about saying it that afternoon and had decided, in a way she did not think she would be able to undo, that she was not going to say it tonight, and possibly not this week, and possibly not at all in the version of the apartment they were currently in.

She watched him put the clementines in the bowl. He took one out of the bowl after he put them all in, and peeled it standing at the counter, and ate it in sections, and offered her one without speaking, the way he had offered her things for four years, and she took it and said thank you and ate two sections and put the rest on a saucer.

He said: *You hungry? I could make something.*

She said: *I ate.*

He said: *Okay.*

He went into the bedroom to change out of the climbing clothes. She heard the chalk bag hit the floor. She heard him swear quietly at something — a buckle, a lace, the small mechanical thing he swore at every Sunday — and the swearing was the thing she had loved at twenty-five, the way his irritation was always at the object and never at the person, and she still loved it, and she sat at the table with the clementine on the saucer and felt the loving as a fact about her, not as a thing that was going to do any work in the room.

Adrien came back into the kitchen in sweatpants and the grey t-shirt with the hole at the collar. He opened the fridge and stood looking into it for a while. He said, into the fridge: *Did you talk to your mom this week?*

She said: *No.*

He said: *Mm.*

He took out the leftover dal from Thursday and put it in a pot. He stirred the dal with the wooden spoon that was too long for the pot, the one they had been meaning to replace for two years.

Adrien put the dal in two bowls. He put one in front of her. He sat down opposite her. He said: *You sure you're okay?*

She said: *Yeah.*

He looked at her for a second longer than he usually did. Not long enough to be a question. Long enough to be a noting. He had noticed something. He did not name what he had noticed. He picked up his spoon.

She picked up her spoon.

They ate the dal. The fridge cycled on. The platform tab in the next room blinked, and Tobias's message sat unanswered in the thread, and the meter ran, and she did not say the thing, and he did not ask the thing, and the count, which had started at one when she shut the door at eleven that morning, ticked over to two.

System: unslop.
Designed by: Rachel Horst (April 2026)
Models: claude-opus-4-7
Seed: A woman builds an automated creative process. The process is so complex that each iteration costs more than the last. By the time she understands what it's making, the meter is past anything she can pay.